

PREMIUM

Pre-Departure Checklist

From visa approved to checking in with your school

2-4 weeks before departure

- Check your visa's validity dates and confirm you're not travelling more than 30 days before your I-20's program start date
- Check your passport's remaining validity
- Confirm your housing arrangements with your school
- Confirm your health insurance meets your school's requirement, if applicable

The week before

- Save or print: passport photo page, visa page, signed I-20, and SEVIS fee receipt
- Confirm your arrival details with your school's international student office
- Share your itinerary and emergency contacts with someone at home

Day of travel

- Arrive at the airport with sufficient buffer time
- Keep your passport, signed I-20, and SEVIS fee receipt in your hand luggage - not checked baggage

At the US port of entry

A Customs and Border Protection officer makes the final entry decision, and can ask questions consistent with your I-20 and application.

- Be ready to show your signed I-20 and SEVIS fee receipt alongside your passport and visa

After you arrive: check in with your school

Most schools require a mandatory international student check-in shortly after arrival, which validates your SEVIS record as "active" - this is a genuine legal requirement, separate from simply enrolling in classes.

- Complete your school's check-in process as instructed by your DSO
- Maintain full-time enrolment and understand your specific on-campus work limits before taking any paid work

— Talk to your DSO before you consider any off-campus training (CPT) or post-completion work (OPT) - both require separate authorisation, not automatic under your visa